Vancouver Public Schools: A district in financial crisis with questions about administrative priorities

Vancouver Public Schools (VPS), the ninth-largest district in Washington State with roughly 22,000 students, Vancouver Public Schools Vancouver Public Schools **faces an escalating financial emergency marked by three consecutive years of state apportionment advances, a fund balance drawn to near zero,** The Columbian **and projected deficits exceeding $20 million.** The Columbian The district cut 262 positions and $35 million from its 2024–25 budget, KGM The Columbian yet only about 19–20 of those eliminated roles came from central administration — roughly 7% of total cuts — while over 113 classroom teaching positions were slashed. OSPI Community critics point to a 48% growth in district staffing over the past decade even as enrollment declined, ClarkCountyToday raising pointed questions about whether the district office has been adequately right-sized relative to classrooms. Meanwhile, the roles of HR Director Jeff Fish and CFO/COO Brett Blechschmidt — two administrators central to staffing and financial decisions — remain largely obscured from public scrutiny.

Executive compensation reached $412,000 while the district bled positions

The highest-paid employee at VPS in 2024–25 was **Superintendent Jeff Snell, whose total compensation reached approximately $412,544** according to GovSalaries data GovSalaries — a figure that includes his base salary, a 7% tax-sheltered annuity contribution, $500/month vehicle allowance, vacation cashout, and health benefits. The Columbian His contract, approved in March 2021, started at $275,000 and escalated annually with built-in raises and COLAs. The Columbian OSPI S-275 personnel data for 2023–24 listed his salary at **$356,835**. OpenGovPay By comparison, the median VPS employee earned roughly $80,100 that year. GovSalaries OpenGovPay

Snell left VPS after four years — effective end of the 2024–25 school year — to become Executive Director of the Washington Association of School Administrators (WASA). The Columbian The Columbian During his tenure, the district approved the largest budget cuts in its history, The Columbian The Columbian received financial warnings from the state, and drew down its fund balance from $7 million to just **$195,180**. The Columbian The Columbian He did accept a 15.2% pay cut as part of the 2024–25 austerity measures, and all central office administrators on the management salary schedule took 9 unpaid furlough days. The Columbian

Snell's predecessor, **Steve Webb, received a $455,000 separation payout** ClarkCountyToday in two lump-sum installments after being placed on administrative leave in February 2021. ClarkCountyToday Webb had led the district since 2008. His final-year total compensation (2020–21) was approximately **$336,000**, The Columbian which included a $33,408/year tax-sheltered annuity, up to $29,181 in annual vacation cashout, and a $4,000 doctoral stipend. The Columbian The $455,000 payout included a mutual non-disparagement clause and a waiver of legal claims. ClarkCountyToday

Superintendent salaries across Clark County for 2023–24 showed VPS in the mid-range: **Evergreen's John Boyd earned $335,760** wa The Columbian (base), Battle Ground's Denny Waters earned $272,325, and Camas's

John Anzalone earned $265,133. The Columbian Among enrollment-comparable districts statewide, Kent's superintendent earned $355,000 and Federal Way's $323,616. wa Neither **Jeff Fish's** nor **Brett Blechschmidt's** exact compensation figures are available in public salary databases, though their positions on the VPS management salary schedule suggest approximate ranges of **$150,000–$180,000** for Fish (Executive Director) and **$200,000–$250,000** for Blechschmidt (Associate Superintendent/CFO), prior to his appointment as interim superintendent.

The $35 million cut fell overwhelmingly on classrooms, not the central office

On March 12, 2024, the VPS Board of Directors unanimously approved $35 million in budget reductions The Columbian — roughly 9% of the district's $324 million annual budget — eliminating approximately 262 FTE positions. The breakdown reveals where the cuts actually landed:

Category	Positions cut
Elementary teachers	50
Secondary teachers	63
Teachers on Special Assignment (TOSAs)	33
Counselors	10
Teacher librarians	9
Clerks	16
Custodial staff	~29
Central office positions	**~19–20**
Other (unspecified)	~32
Total	**~262**

Central office positions accounted for **roughly 7.3% of total cuts by headcount**. VPS has framed this differently, claiming that "the percentage of staff cut at Central Office was the highest of any employee group during the reduction in force." Vancouver Public Schools This statement refers to the proportion of central office's own headcount that was eliminated — not the share of total district cuts. Community survey results from November 2023 through February 2024 (over 2,000 respondents) The Columbian showed residents "strongly opposed cutting teachers and increasing class sizes, while expressing substantial support for making more cuts at the district's central office." The Columbian

The district claims it has "decreased the staffing level and costs at the central office over the last several years" Vancouver Public Schools and has "repurposed previous roles, such as Deputy Superintendent, to positions that directly support schools." Vancouver Public Schools However, a critical caveat appears on VPS's own budget page: the district's central office staffing analysis "does not include teachers on special assignment (TOSAs) who may have desks in the Central Office" Vancouver Public Schools Vancouver Public Schools — a potentially significant exclusion that could mask the true size of the administrative footprint. The full organizational chart and detailed Program 97 (central administration) expenditure history from F-195 reports were not available in pre-compiled public form during this research. Vancouver Public Schools

Notably, in 2020–21 — even amid budget pressures — VPS created **four new administrative positions** for diversity, equity, and inclusion: Chief Equity Officer, Special Services Compliance Manager, Education Ombudsman, and Assistant General Counsel. ClarkCountyToday

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Three years of emergency borrowing: an unprecedented cash crisis

VPS has required state emergency apportionment advances for **three consecutive years** — the only Clark County district to do so. The Columbian The escalation is stark:

- **2023–24**: $15.5 million (fully granted) The Columbian
- **2024–25**: $18.5 million (fully granted) The Columbian
- **2025–26**: $21.4 million requested — **the largest apportionment advance request OSPI has ever received** — but only $8.7 million was granted The Columbian

After the state denied the full request, VPS's board authorized borrowing from the Clark County Treasurer's Office The Columbian via interest-bearing registered warrants The Columbian in December 2025, with borrowing capacity ranging from $6 million to $16.5 million depending on the month. The Columbian Clark County Treasurer Alishia Topper warned publicly: "This is the third consecutive year Vancouver Public Schools has needed a large apportionment advance, and your fund balance has been in decline. While the state bears a large share of responsibility, **the district's decisions have also contributed to the situation**." The Columbian She added that "county treasurers are not designed to provide long, ongoing operating loans to school districts." The Columbian

The projected deficit for 2026–27 is **$20.15 million**. The Columbian OSPI assigned VPS a low financial health score and issued a financial warning The Columbian for 2023–24 — the only Clark County district to receive one. Blechschmidt identified five driving forces: recurring deficits, enrollment decreases, increased staffing costs, special education underfunding The Columbian ($31.4 million gap over five years), The Columbian and rising materials/operating costs. The Columbian VPS also received state auditor findings in 2021 and 2024 for procurement compliance violations The Columbian — breaking a streak of 13 consecutive clean audits. Vancouver Public Schools Vancouver Public Schools

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How VPS compares to peer districts on administrative staffing

NCES data allows a standardized comparison of district-level administrative FTE across similar Washington districts. After the 2024–25 cuts, **VPS reports 21.31 district administrator FTEs** (ed) — down from 28.55 in 2022–23, (Ballotpedia) a 25% reduction:

District	Enrollment	Dist. admin FTE	Admin per 1,000 students	Supt. base salary
Vancouver PS (2024–25)	~21,800	21.31	**0.98**	$300,675
Evergreen PS (2022–23)	~22,600	32.21	1.43	$335,760
Puyallup (2023–24)	~22,900	28.17	1.23	~$358,570
Battle Ground (2023–24)	~13,500	16.00	1.19	$242,493
Kent (2023–24)	~25,700	29.63	1.15	$355,000
Bethel (2023–24)	~21,500	21.65	1.01	$268,529
Federal Way (2023–24)	~21,800	18.34	0.84	$323,616
Camas (2023–24)	~7,200	6.00	0.83	$220,000

By this metric, VPS now has one of the leaner district admin ratios at **0.98 per 1,000 students** — below the peer average of approximately 1.10, and well below Clark County neighbor Evergreen (1.43). However, this NCES "district administrators" category is narrowly defined and does not capture all central office personnel. When district administrative support staff are included, VPS's total central office footprint rises to **78.30 FTE** (3.1% of all 2,504 staff). (ed) (NCES) VPS's central administration expenditures, according to OSPI data for one available year, were **$14.8 million (5.4% of total expenditures)** — slightly below Evergreen's 5.6% and the statewide average of 5.9%. (ClarkCountyToday)

The critical counterpoint, raised by community critic Larry Roe, is that VPS's **total employee count grew from 2,225 in 2014 to 3,300 in 2024 — a 48.3% increase — while enrollment dropped** (ClarkCountyToday) **from 23,065 to 22,014**, (clarkcountytoday) a loss of over 1,000 students. Evergreen, by comparison, grew staffing only 5.8% over the same period (ClarkCountyToday) while losing 4,225 students. (The Columbian) (clarkcountytoday) This disparity suggests systemic overstaffing regardless of how central-office-specific metrics compare.

Jeff Fish: a legally trained HR director operating below the radar

Jeff Fish serves as Executive Director of Human Resources at VPS, (LinkedIn) (ZoomInfo) a role he has held since approximately May 2022. His professional background is distinctive for an HR director: he holds a **Juris**

Doctor from The Catholic University of America (RocketReach) and spent much of his career in legal and labor relations roles, including Labor & Employment Senior Legal Counsel, HR Legal Counsel at Portland Public Schools, positions at the Portland Development Commission, Clackamas Education Service District, and Legal Aid Services of Oregon. (ZoomInfo)

Fish's public profile at VPS is **remarkably low**. No media quotes, interviews, public statements, or attributed board presentations by Fish were found in any local news outlet — including The Columbian, Clark County Today, KATU, or OPB. His name does not appear in publicly available coverage of VPS labor negotiations with VEA, VAESP, or SEIU, even though as Executive Director of HR he would be the district's lead on collective bargaining strategy. Media coverage of bargaining and staffing issues consistently quotes Superintendent Snell or Communications Director Jessica Roberts rather than Fish.

The investigative question of Fish's role in decisions to use contract staffing agencies (Soliant, Amergis/Maxim, Pioneer) rather than recruiting permanent staff directly remains **unanswered by publicly available records**. No board meeting minutes, media articles, or public statements linking Fish to staffing agency decisions were located. The HR department at VPS comprises approximately 5 employees, (RocketReach) and national staffing agencies Amergis and others maintain active job postings in Vancouver, WA for positions including school psychologists, speech-language pathologists, and special education teachers — positions that fall squarely within HR's recruitment purview. Whether the decision to outsource these roles to agencies reflects HR's inability to recruit, a deliberate operational choice, or decisions made outside HR's authority is not documented in publicly accessible records.

Brett Blechschmidt: the financial architect who became interim superintendent

Brett Blechschmidt is the most visible administrator in VPS's financial operations. With **30+ years in education administration** — 19 at Educational Service District 112 and 11 at VPS (The Columbian) — he has served as (Vancouver Public Schools) Assistant Superintendent and Chief Financial Officer, then Associate Superintendent and Chief Operating Officer, and was appointed **Interim Superintendent for the 2025–26 school year** (Vancouver Public Schools +2) in May 2025 (with an agreement not to seek the permanent position). (Vancouver Public Schools) (The Columbian)

Blechschmidt has been VPS's **primary budget presenter to the board for years**, delivering annual budget recommendations, consensus budgets, levy options, and financial updates. He is extensively quoted in The Columbian on budget crises, levy discussions, and emergency funding measures. At the December 2025 board meeting where the county borrowing resolution was passed, he outlined $7 million in new reductions and announced the closure of Flex Academy. (The Columbian) He acknowledged the district "needs to start restoring fund balance reserves" and stated: "When we've exhausted nearly all of our cash reserves, at some point in time, we need to reverse that flow." (The Columbian)

As CFO, Blechschmidt oversaw VPS's fiscal services department, which includes the **purchasing department** (managed by David Hurt). (Vancouver Public Schools) This department handles purchase orders, bid management, inventory, and contracted services. His signatory authority on vendor contracts is not explicitly documented in

publicly available records, but his position as the district's highest-ranking financial officer prior to the superintendent gave him functional authority over fiscal operations. Under Washington state law (RCW 28A.335.190), formal bidding is required for goods purchases over $75,000 and public works over $100,000, ospi but **professional service contracts — such as staffing agencies — may not be subject to the same competitive bidding requirements**, instead falling under district-adopted policies for professional services.

The specific **dollar threshold at which VPS requires board approval** for service contracts versus superintendent/designee authority was not found in publicly available records. VPS Board Policy 6220 (Bid or Request for Proposal Requirements) exists CitizenPortal.ai but was not fully accessible. Staffing agency contracts with Soliant, Amergis/Maxim, or Pioneer were not found in publicly available board meeting minutes or bid postings — though this does not prove they don't exist, as they may fall below board approval thresholds or be categorized as professional services not requiring public bid.

A notable personal detail: Jennifer Blechschmidt, who appears to be Brett's spouse, serves as principal at Eisenhower Elementary School The Columbian within VPS. The Columbian He received the WASA Twenty-Year Award in 2025 for two decades of service to public school districts. ESD 112

Community critics, forensic questions, and the accountability gap

Larry Roe has emerged as the most prominent community critic of VPS finances. A PhD chemist and retired Intel engineering manager, The Columbian Roe ran unsuccessfully for the VPS Board in both 2023 and November 2025 (receiving 40.76% of the vote in the latter). The Columbian His detailed financial analyses, published as letters and opinion pieces in Clark County Today, have raised pointed criticisms:

- Over three school years, VPS spending exceeded tax receipts by $9 million, $15 million, and $7 million respectively ClarkCountyToday clarkcountytoday
- The district had to seek what he called "payday loans" — state apportionment advances — in January 2024 and October 2024 ClarkCountyToday
- Per-student spending doubled over 10 years while test scores continued to decline ClarkCountyToday
- Property taxes rose approximately 254.8% from 2014 to 2024 ClarkCountyToday
- In 2023–24, $8.5 million was collected in the Capital Projects Fund and $8.8 million was transferred to the General Fund — suggesting levy funds were being used to "balance the books"

Roe has called for "a complete audit of the district." ClarkCountyToday Even The Columbian's editorial board, while endorsing his opponent, acknowledged Roe as "a strong candidate" The Columbian whose concerns about the board's decision to spend reserves down to $195,180 were legitimate.

Forensic accountant Tiffany Couch — founder/CEO of Acuity Forensics in Vancouver, WA, Ccbawashington a nationally recognized CPA/CFF and Certified Fraud Examiner Acuityforensics — has analyzed Clark County school district finances publicly, though her documented work relates specifically to **Battle Ground School**

District rather than VPS. No published forensic analysis of VPS by Couch was located. Her prominence in local financial accountability circles and her Vancouver base make her a relevant figure in the broader conversation about district financial transparency.

The watchdog website **Southwest Washington Education (swweducation.org)** has published critical financial analyses, filed public records requests for superintendent compensation and performance reviews, and hosted school board candidate questionnaires. The site has published Larry Roe's analyses and critiqued VPS's equity policies and administrator evaluation processes.

At the board level, the March 12, 2024 meeting where the $35 million cut was approved drew dozens of community members. The Columbian The Columbian Paraeducator Christopher Smith challenged administrators directly: "As you burn out your staff, there are limited replacements. This is not a renewable resource. Have you been in a classroom with 40 or more students?" The Columbian VEA President Jamie Anderson noted: "Cutting 100-plus classroom teachers — I don't see how that minimizes impact to the classroom." The Columbian +2 Fort Vancouver High School students subsequently walked out to protest The Columbian disproportionate cuts to their school. KOIN.com

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Conclusion: structural crisis with unresolved governance questions

VPS faces a genuine structural funding crisis — one shared to varying degrees by districts statewide as K-12's share of the state general fund dropped from 52.4% in 2019 to 43.1% in 2024. NCESD Special education underfunding, ClarkCountyToday enrollment declines, The Columbian and the expiration of $64.5 million in ESSER funds Vancouver Public Schools ClarkCountyToday are real, documented pressures. The Columbian Vancouver Public Schools The 2025 Legislature's passage of SB 5263 (eliminating the special education cap) and HB 2049 (increasing levy authority) may provide some relief. WEA

But the specific decisions made by VPS leadership — the 48% staffing growth during enrollment decline, ClarkCountyToday the creation of new administrative positions during budget stress, the drawdown of reserves to near zero, and **three consecutive years of unprecedented emergency borrowing** The Columbian The Columbian — are choices, not inevitabilities. The county treasurer's public admonishment that "the district's decisions have also contributed to the situation" The Columbian reflects a bipartisan recognition that VPS's crisis has both external and internal causes.

The governance questions remain unresolved. Jeff Fish's role in staffing agency decisions, Blechschmidt's signatory authority on vendor contracts, the specific dollar thresholds for board approval of service contracts, and the full accounting of whether positions were quietly reclassified or recreated after the RIF — none of these are answerable from publicly available records. **VPS's BoardDocs portal, which houses the detailed meeting minutes and consent agendas that could illuminate these questions, blocks automated access.** A comprehensive public records request targeting board consent agendas, vendor contract approvals, HR staffing reports, and management salary schedules from 2022 through 2025 would be the most direct path to filling these gaps. As VPS prepares for a new permanent superintendent Vancouver Public Schools +3 — Dr. Ricardo "Rocky"

Torres-Morales Vancouver Public Schools — and stares down a $20.15 million projected deficit for 2026–27, The Columbian the pressure for genuine administrative accountability will only intensify.